

序 · EPIGRAPH

“A drawing is a promise the building rarely keeps. This book is an account of the distance between the two — written by the person who made both.”

無用 · IN·UTILE · AUTHOR'S NOTE

TAEYOUNG RO · 노태영

行 PRAXIS · 論 ESSAYS · 思 THEORY
SELF-CRITIQUE EDITION

無用

in utile

Arguing with *my own* drawings

SELECTED WORKS & SELF-CRITIQUE
2018 - 2025 · ARCHITECTURE

A4 / A3 · PERFECT-BOUND
EDITION OF ONE

26

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Works, and what they got wrong

Six projects in the order I made them. Each opens with what it was meant to be, shows what was drawn, and ends with what I would now say to the student who drew it. The buildings do not change; only the reading does.

I

Praxis

행 · 行

01 PAVILION · 02 THRESHOLD HOUSING
03 TIDAL LIBRARY · 04 SEONGSU BLOCK
05 CHEONGGYE · 06 QUIET ANNEX



The Unbuilt Pavilion

A second-year studio project, revisited six years later.

YEAR	2019 · Studio IV
TYPE	Open pavilion · 1 bay
ROLE	Sole author
SITE	Riverbank, Sejong
TOOLS	Graphite, ink on trace · model 1:50

The pavilion was conceived as a threshold rather than a destination — a frame that registers the passage of weather and light across a single open bay. The structure resolves into four points of contact with the ground.

寫

DROP HERO — PAVILION RENDER / MODEL PHOTO (3:4)



KEY DRAWING — LONG SECTION 1:100

Fig. 01 — Long section, 1:100. Graphite & ink on trace, 2019.

行 01 / 12



GROUND PLAN 1:200



NORTH ELEVATION

Fig. 02 — Ground plan, 1:200. The four-point structure carries an open bay.



JUNCTION DETAIL 1:20

Fig. 03 — North elev., 1:200.

Fig. 04 — Eaves junction, 1:20.

Brief & site conditions

The proposal organises a single timber bay over a shared, top-lit threshold. Circulation runs along the north edge, leaving the south face uninterrupted for the river. The roof folds to admit indirect light while shedding rain to a central channel, and the whole resolves as one tectonic move from ground to ridge.

Materials were specified as cross-laminated timber on a board-marked concrete plinth. The structure was meant to read at a distance as a frame and, up close, as a careful set of joints — a building that explains how it stands.

The pavilion was never built. It survives only as drawings and a single 1:50 model, photographed on the studio floor the night before the review.

批 “The court is beautiful in section and useless in plan.”

批 CRITIQUE · 2026

I designed the light before I designed the work that was supposed to happen under it — and it shows in how thinly the programme is described. The roof does too much; it hides an unresolved plan beneath a gesture.

The drawing is honest about ambition and silent about how anyone would actually enter. Six years on, the lesson is simple and unflattering: I had drawn a mood and called it a building.

WHAT I'D KEEP

The instinct to make a single structural idea legible was right. The failure was scope, not sensibility — and that distinction is the reason this project opens the book.

02

Threshold Housing

사이 주거

Forty units arranged around a court I designed before I understood its use.

YEAR	2021 · Studio VII
TYPE	Collective housing · 40 units
ROLE	Sole author
SITE	Mangwon-dong, Seoul

Three timber volumes share a single top-lit court; circulation runs the north edge so the south face stays open to the lane. The roof folds to bring indirect light to the deep plan.

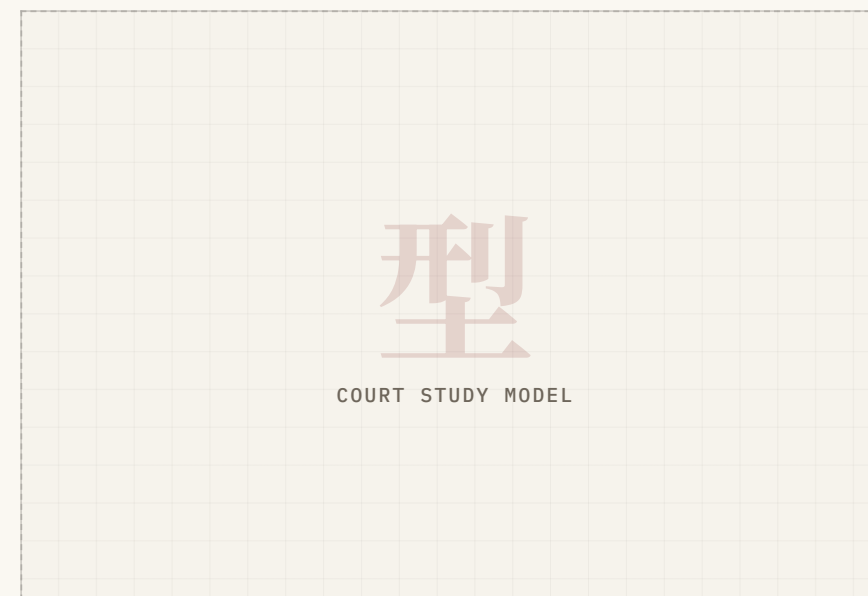
寫

DROP HERO — COURTYARD VIEW / MODEL (4:5)



Fig. 05 — Typical floor, 1:200. The court is the only space every unit must cross.

Units are paired across a shared stair; each pair brackets a recessed entry — the *si*, the in-between — so that arriving home is a sequence of thresholds rather than a single door. The section keeps the court in view from every landing.



批 CRITIQUE

Forty families, and I drew the court for the perspective, not for them. The thresholds are lovely and the units behind them are mean — single-aspect, deep, under-lit.

I would trade two metres of court for a second window in every plan. The internship taught me that; the studio didn't.

Two projects, set against each other

Where Praxis judges projects one at a time, the essays put two in the same room. The argument here is not which is better, but what they share — and what the repetition of a mistake says about the person making it.

II

Essays

론 · 論

ON THE COURT, AND THE WINDOW
IT KEPT COSTING ME



The court was always an excuse

Twice now I have organised a building around a beautiful void and let the rooms around it suffer. The pavilion did it with a roof; the housing did it with a court. In both, the seductive drawing arrived first and the plan was bent to keep it.

This is not a problem of talent but of order — of what I let myself solve before I had earned the right to. A void is the easiest thing to draw and the hardest to justify, because it asks nothing of programme until programme is the only thing left.

The correction is procedural. Plan the dark rooms first. Let the void be what remains, not what begins. The internship year, for all its frustrations, was the first time I was made to.

批 MARGIN

Two projects, one habit. The honest portfolio names the habit.

“A void is the easiest thing to draw and the hardest to justify.”



Fig. 06 — Two voids, redrawn at the same scale to compare what each subtracts from its plan.

The position the work is measured against

A short statement of what I now think architecture is for. It is placed last on purpose: a thesis earns its right to be stated only after the work that tested it.



Theory

사 · 思

USEFUL USELESSNESS ·
無用 AS A WORKING METHOD



On useful uselessness



用 — *wú yòng*, the useless — is not a rejection of function. It is a discipline: the part of a building that does no measurable work is the part most exposed to judgement, and therefore the part that must be most exact. A threshold carries no load and decides everything.

My early projects mistook the useless for the free. They are not the same. The free is unaccountable; the useless is accountable precisely because it has no excuse. This portfolio is built to hold me to that.

無用 · the useless, drawn exactly.

無用

A threshold carries no load and decides everything.

Taeyoung Ro

歷 EDUCATION

2019–25	M.Arch, Seoul National University · thesis: Quiet Annex
2015–19	B.Sc Architecture, Hanyang University · cum laude

歷 PRACTICE

2023	Architecture Intern, SoA · Seongsu mixed-use, DD set
2022	Summer Intern, Office of · competition team

歷 SKILLS & AWARDS

Tools	Rhino · AutoCAD · Affinity · hand drafting · timber & concrete modelling
2024	SNU Thesis Prize, shortlist

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SET IN BODONI MODA · SPECTRAL · PRETENDARD · CORMORANT GARAMOND · IBM PLEX MONO · NOTO SERIF KR
A4 PORTRAIT / A3 LANDSCAPE · CMYK · PSO UNCOATED v3 · CRIMSON PRIME · 批 TWO-VOICE SYSTEM